

An illustration on the left side of the page shows three women in profile, facing right. They are wearing long, flowing green robes with vertical pleats. Their hair is light-colored and wavy. The woman at the top has a green headband. The woman in the middle has a black headband. The woman at the bottom has a black headband and a large, ornate earring. The background is a solid teal color. In the top right corner, there are some dark, thin branches. In the bottom right corner, there is a small orange and yellow decorative element.

Odin Seeks the Runes

The cosmos was new and full of life: birds filled the sky, fish the sea and animals the land; the Sun and Moon raced across the heavens, and humans thrived in Midgard. But Odin the All-Father was worried.

His raven spies had reported that the giants were plotting revenge in Jotunheim, and trolls prowled ever closer to Asgard. Odin needed an advantage – something that he could use to protect Asgard. He decided to learn the runes.

Runes were not just symbols to write with on wood and stone, they also gave magical powers to those who could read them.

“Rune” means “secret”, and Odin knew that learning how they worked would be difficult. “But when has it ever been easy to obtain anything worthwhile?” he thought. So Odin set out to visit Yggdrasil, and the Well of Urd where the three Norns lived. These mysterious beings had full knowledge of the runes, and by carving them into the World Tree’s bark they controlled the fate of all living things. Odin pondered what to do. “I need to prove that I am worthy of the runes,” he thought. “A sacrifice! But no ordinary sacrifice...”